

NANYANG TECHNOLOGICAL UNIVERSITY
INTERDISCIPLINARY COLLABORATIVE CORE (ICC)
ACADEMIC YEAR: 2024-2025, SEMESTER 1
INDIVIDUAL ASSIGNMENT

Module Code and Title: ML0004 Career & Innovative Enterprise for the Future World
Assignment Title: Prototyping Conversation
Weightage: 22%
Deadline: Week 8, 10 Oct 2024 (Thu), 23:59hr

Part A: Informational Interview Details

Date of Informational Interview:	23/09/2024
Name of the interviewee (mentor/ professional) – Full name is required:	Abdul Hamid Ahmad
The organisation employed at:	Freelance (previously a Senior Consultant at Avantus Pte Ltd)
Job Title:	AI Consultant
Mode of interview: (online, face-to-face)	Online Zoom Meeting
E-mail address: (preferably workplace e-mail)/ LinkedIn Profile address / Social Media link of interviewee)	https://www.linkedin.com/in/abdul-hamid-ahmad

Key Informational Interview Questions (maximum 5):

Question 1:

From my understanding, your career in the tech field has been through many different roles such as an IT engineer at IBM, then a network engineer and now delving into the world of AI. I understand that many undergrads do not continue their one path in their career paths, thus, how do you find the tech field facilitation of such transitions or accepting of such changes?

Question 2:

Do you believe that interning in the same type of role across different companies provides a more valuable experience and deeper expertise, or do you think that gaining exposure to different roles within the tech field is more beneficial for long-term career development? What factors should students consider when deciding between these two paths?

Question 3:

I understand that you recently completed a master's degree in AI at NTU. Do you think employers still prioritize formal education, given the abundance of resources available for self-learning? Additionally, how important do you believe pursuing a graduate degree, like a master's, is in the tech field today?

Question 4:

From your experience, what do employers prioritize more: technical skills or soft skills? Additionally, how do they weigh portfolios against academic grades when evaluating candidates?

Question 5:

How do you perceive the overall work-life balance in Singaporean companies? Is the work-life balance more influenced by the sector of the company, or is it predominantly dependent on

whether the company is in the tech industry?

Part B: Reflection (word count 500 words $\pm$ 10%)

I chose to interview a seasoned professional in the tech field, while he is currently an AI educator, he has transitioned between various roles – from an IT engineer at IBM to a network engineer. I felt that such a trait is important as it helps me gain a comprehensive understanding of the evolving landscape of technology careers, allowing me to learn about career progression also.

During the interview, it was reassuring to know that despite an increased uptake in courses related to technology, the demand for tech professionals is still growing both locally and internationally. However, it was surprising to learn that the pivots in his career were not deliberate but instead his commitment to being a network engineer allowed for exposure to different roles which he could then pivot to with related experience in the projects. Thus, I should aim to remain open to transitioning between roles and specializations, as this can enhance my career trajectory and broaden my expertise, and the tech field will nurture me automatically. This led to the conclusion that I should go against the trend of interning different roles to gain a broader understanding of the industry and instead I should intern the same type of role, but different companies and it will also give me the opportunity to learn about other roles due to the different projects available and different sizes of the companies will force me to undertake different roles too. Furthermore, the industry apparently favours specialists more than generalists.

The discussion on educational qualifications reassured me that a degree is instrumental in the current society but the choice for further studies depends on my employment situation years after graduation. I should thus focus on building up my soft skills to better able work in the working environment while aiming to seek a master's to enhance my career growth, while I may not reap the benefits immediately to education, it is a worthwhile investment. I should also start building up my portfolio by coding projects related to data analytics such as participating in Kaggle competitions as technical skills gives companies the reassurance that I can immediately hop onto ongoing projects without much onboarding training if I were to not go into the government sector.

Regarding work-life balance, I have a flexible mindset and am willing to trade some balance for increased pay. However, if my priorities shift in the future, I could consider moving towards the government sector, which typically offers more stable pay, benefits, and a better work-life balance. In contrast, sectors like banking are known for their demanding hours, often requiring 12-hour workdays, even in tech roles.

In conclusion, I will focus on enhancing both my technical and soft skills by engaging in coding projects to prove my immediate employability. Additionally, as I explore internship opportunities, I will consider my work-life balance preferences, staying flexible about roles that offer better stability, like those in the government sector. I will also consider staying in a specific role such as a data analyst but instead venture between different companies for different internship for the opportunity to work on projects with exposure to other technical roles in the tech industry.

(Word Count: 527)